

other has moved us but little.<sup>1</sup>

A century on, what can we say about those words? On the one hand, they feel archaic. We of the twenty-first century are hyperaware of the importance of efficiency and the economic value of productivity gains. Our workplaces are—at least when it comes to the building of material objects—incredibly well organized compared with those of Taylor's day.

On the other hand, Taylor's words strike me as completely contemporary. For all of our vaunted efficiency in the making of things, our economy is still incredibly wasteful. This waste comes not from the inefficient organization of work but rather from working on the wrong things—and on an industrial scale. As Peter Drucker said, "There is surely nothing quite so useless as doing with great efficiency what should not be done at all."<sup>2</sup>

And yet we are doing the wrong things efficiently all the time. It is hard to come by a solid estimate of just how wasteful modern work is, but there is no shortage of anecdotes. In my consulting and travels talking about the Lean Startup, I hear the same message consistently from employees of companies big and small. In every industry we see endless stories of failed launches, ill-conceived projects, and large-batch death spirals. I consider this misuse of people's time a criminally negligent waste of human creativity and potential.

What percentage of all this waste is preventable? I think a much larger proportion than we currently realize. Most people I meet believe that in their industry at least, projects fail for good reasons: projects are inherently risky, market conditions are unpredictable, "big company people" are intrinsically uncreative. Some believe that if we just slowed everything down and used a more careful process, we could reduce the failure rate by doing fewer projects of higher quality. Others believe that certain people have an innate gift of knowing the right thing to build. If we can find enough of these visionaries and virtuosos, our problems will be solved. These "solutions" were once considered state of the art in the nineteenth century. too. before people knew about modern management.